same time. The battle to become their successor had left the BJP looking like a Hindu Divided Family.

Swaraj as leader of the party in the Lok Sabha had been one hopeful—with her blazing red sindoor and big bindi, she might have come straight out of a *saas–bahu* set. A terrific campaigner and forceful public speaker, she had the backing of Advani who had groomed her. There was also Jaitley, the suave lawyer and election strategist, who was leader of the party in the Rajya Sabha. He had a strong equation with Modi, having given the Gujarat chief minister sharp legal advice through his many battles with the judiciary. He had even got his Rajya Sabha entry from Gujarat.

Swaraj and Jaitley disliked each other and their 'camps' would often accuse the other of planting stories against the other. Once a photograph came out in the newspapers of Sushma 'blessing' the Reddy brothers of Karnataka after they had just been indicted in a mining scam. 'I know you have got this photo from Jaitley's office only to discredit me,' she told us.

A more charitable explanation of the Sushma–Jaitley cold war would be to call it 'sibling rivalry' between two individuals sharing a common space. Swaraj, in fact, once told me in half-jest, '*Arre*, *tum toh Arun ke dost ho* [You are Arun's friend], you go for a walk with him, you will only project him!'

Yes, Jaitley was part of our 'middle-aged' walking club in Delhi's picturesque Siri Fort forest park before he moved to the more upscale Lodi Gardens, but to be honest, he liked to talk as much as walk! The loquacious, extroverted Jaitley is a natural raconteur—from politics to cricket to just simple gossip, he has more than a story a day to offer. As brilliant a host as he is a lawyer, Jaitley is an aficionado of fine food, and his parties are examples of big-hearted Punjabi hospitality, though his taste in cholesterol-heavy Moti Mahal *burra* kebabs probably does not please his physician. I don't think I have met a politician with a wider circle of friends outside politics; within the power corridors, however, he was feared as much as admired. Feared because he never cloaked his fierce ambition in diplomacy, admired for his sophisticated and erudite debating skills. He was also totally